

focuses on expenditure targeting to deliver results and savings?

That though is not on the agenda. Successive regimes have conveniently bypassed the recommendations of fifth and sixth pay commissions and simply paid up. They also ignored the reports of the Expenditure Reforms Commission led by K.P. Geethakrishnan on downsizing.

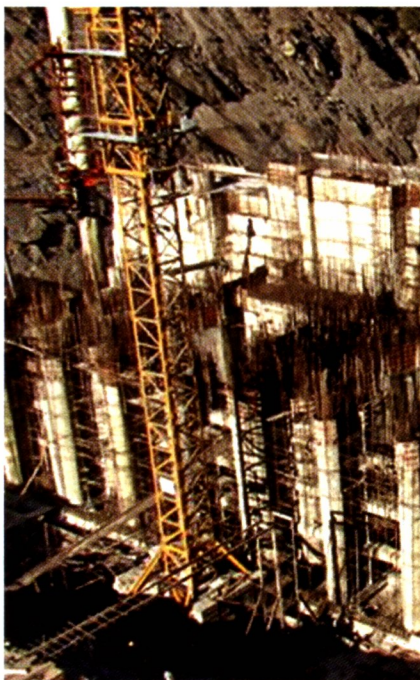
Efficiency is not on the agenda. Every minister and secretary in the government of India has an email ID, a computer, and are on a LAN system. All secretaries in the government have video conference facilities. Are they being used? Last week, eight secretaries of the Union Government in a meeting presided over by the cabinet secretary spent an hour discussing a critical issue: How officers in ministries and departments should be prevented from procuring, borrowing or cadging laptops and mobile phones from public sector undertakings? Shouldn't the Government be providing tools of productivity?

It is time someone asked the Government if its austerity programme isn't in conflict with the need to stimulate and revive the economy? Not just Obama, every head of state in the world has exhorted spending to come out of recession and slowdown. Yes, this "austerity" is about spending public monies and maybe about introducing restraint in expenses of MPs and ministers. But in an age when governments discuss tax credits to ramp up consumer spending for demand revival, should India be talking its economy down? And finally if all that the Government will save from the entire exercise is a few crores, what is the big idea? Obviously, the Congress approach has been all political with no real de-



Systemic ROT

This austerity is in sympathy for farmers. Yet nobody cares that farmers lose over Rs 60,000 crore as produce rots in fields due to poor roads and lack of cold chains. But little has been done to fix farm-to-fork connectivity.



bate on efficacy of the effort and no attention to the concept of "return on investment". It is this attention to symbolism and not outcome that makes this such a hypocritical spectacle, such a cynical exercise.

For the Congress, austerity is clearly not a moral posture. There is no cutting down on the pomposity quotient. There is no shrinking in the size of the cavalcade that trails ministers or liveried staff they order around. The chatterati around the political class have rediscovered Sarojini Naidu and her quip on the cost of keeping the Mahatma poor. If they discovered Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi, the chattering class would realise that for him austerity was about morality. He wove his own clothes, washed them, cleaned his own living quarters and lived on a frugal diet. For the Congress party—or at least some Congressmen—austerity is a political instrument. Unlike Saint Augustine the Congress party is not praying for chastity, it merely wants to appear chaste. Momentarily. ■

Dear DELAYS

As of May 2009, 310 of 591 Government projects are delayed. While the sanctioned costs have already gone up by nearly 10 per cent to Rs 5,74,429 crore, final costs are estimated to go up by 38 per cent or Rs 1,70,000 crore.